

Dear Edgar,

I know I have been gone for some time now. I am alive and well, however, I'm not sure I will stay that way for long. Since I departed from Lyndon, I have taken up a life as an adventurer, however, I am not some fool who romanticizes questing and traveling. The purpose of my adventuring is to save a small town named Norbury, which resides in the south-west region of Thalgrim, from the blight. The purpose of this letter is to tell you my story.

My name, as you know, is Thomas Elnath. I was born on a moonless winter night in the town of Norbury. Norbury was a flourishing fishing village in Thalgrim populated by Dwarves, Humans, and Deepfolk. My grandparents founded Norbury after they migrated from the ocean to the land. At the time of my birth, my father, a triton named Keres Elnath, was the Mayor of Norbury. Soon after my birth, my father succumbed to the plague, and my mother, a human Edith Elnath, became the Mayor of Norbury.

My Mother is a cold and reserved woman. My Grandmother, a triton named Fathryn Elnath, told me that she was not always that way, and that the death of my father made her heart cold. My mother did put effort into raising me. As a child, my mother had me on a strict curriculum where I learned linguistic skills, history, trade, and many other useful skills. I preferred to play by the beach with my close friend Lyla, a human girl.

As a teenager, I began skipping my mother's classes in favor of going on fishing trips with the village fisherman. My mother wanted me to take up the mantle of Mayor when I grew up, however, I wanted to go on fishing trips and adventures to other cities to sell our haul.

The year 1516 was a hard one for the village. Winter was bad. The crops we could grow that far south could not survive the frost. Folks went deep into their food reserves, and those who

didn't have reserves went hungry. The hope that comes from spring was quickly squandered by heavy rain that seemed to have no end. Homes were flooding, and homelessness was on the rise. Our cemetery was not large enough to house the dead, so we started unceremoniously tossing bodies into the ocean to prevent them from rotting in the streets. We knew that the warmer waters that came with summer would bring massive storms, so my mother organized a large-scale fishing trip at the end of spring.

The trip was bearing overwhelming success. Our ship was loaded with tunas the size of grown men, enough sardines to be preserved and feed the village for a year, and exotic marine creatures that could be sold for lots of money to the finer restaurants in Colbrum. The more wizened among us knew it was time for us to end our trip with the haul we had; however, I wanted to venture further into the sea and continue to build our haul. I convinced many of the men that we should continue despite the impending storms. We left it up to a vote, and my side was the victor. Our luck continued, and I was elated at the prospect that my decision was bringing us so much success.

Eventually, the waters started to become too rough. Large waves battered the ship, and heavy rains flooded the deck. We had turned back, but it was too late. We could not navigate in the massive storm we found ourselves in. We were simply at the whims of the extraordinary power of nature. I remember a sudden calm. The wind slowed down, and the waves relented. I stared at the moonless sky as the older fishermen exchanged their final farewells with each other. Just as suddenly as the calm fell upon us, the chaos returned. Winds that could fell oak trees, waves that could swallow castles, and rain that tore our flesh apart. Soon, the ship capsized. I scrambled to get hold of as many of the men as I could before we went under. Once the sea consumed us, I began to swim upwards with the men I had hold of. As I swam, I felt their hands

grab onto me. Panicked for air, they pulled down on my arms and legs, as if they could climb up my body and somehow reach safety. The more they grabbed and pulled me, the lower I sank. I could no longer swim up, however, I tried. I fucking swear I tried with everything I had so save all of the men who had been damned by my hubris.

Soon, they stopped pulling. Their grips loosened, and their struggle ended. I caught a glimpse of them before the currents pulled them each into their watery graves.

I can still see their faces, you know. They come to me in my dreams. They tell me it was my fault. They tell me that I should be dead in their place. They grab me and pull me down to where they are. Then I wake up.

After the capsizing of the ship and the death of the crew, I just... drifted. I let the currents take me, and I hoped they would bring me to my crew. I hoped that I still had a chance to save them, but I didn't. They were gone. Eventually, I found my way back to the surface. I used the stars to navigate the cold ocean. It took me weeks, but I made it back to the shores of Norbury.

I sat on the beach, exhausted and starved. Eventually, someone found me, and soon most of the town of Norbury was on the beach waiting to hear my story, my mother included. I explained what happened, and I confessed to them that it was my fault. Some cried, some just walked away, some just stood in disbelief. My mother said nothing, but she looked down at me in extreme disappointment.

I would have sat on that beach for the rest of my life if Lyla hadn't picked me up. She took me home and helped me recover both physically and mentally. I eventually started getting back to work, but I couldn't go back into the ocean. Whenever I looked at the sea, I could see the faces of the dead in the waves, and if I ever walked into the water, I knew that I would be grabbed by a vengeful spirit.

I worked as a Journeyman. I would leave the village for weeks, sometimes months, to trade our fish at the major cities of Thalgrim. It was good work for me since I hated being home. The only good thing about being home was being with Lyla, however, Lyla eventually left me for another. I understand why. I was rarely around, but it still hurt like hell when she told me. After Lyla left me I had no reason to stay in Norbury.

When I left, I went far, and as you know, I ended up in Lyndon. I put my knowledge of trade and business to use and opened up the Sleeping Dragon Inn. That is when I met you and took you on as my bartender. I have loved my work as an innkeeper however, I have always been haunted by my past. I feel as if a part of me never made it out of that ocean.

Six months ago, I received a letter from my Grandmother. She told me the blight has gotten bad in Norbury. She told me the people are suffering, and she is close to death, and that I must see her before she passes. I left shortly after I received that letter and journeyed to Norbury. It was worse than she said. I would give it one more year before the town is dead.

Despite how I know my mother feels about me, she allowed me to stay in the house to be with my grandmother during her final days. I spoke briefly with my Grandmother during her sparse moments of lucidity. She told me that far south in the forest, past the Ozzen Peaks is a druid winter and that I should speak with him. That he might be able to save out, but nobody believes her.

After the funeral, I decided to oblige my Grandmother in her final request, although I thought it was pointless. I journeyed far into the south and eventually became lost. As I walked through tall spruce trees, trying to find my way, I was approached by an arctic fox. I began following Fox through the cold forest until I was led to a druid grove. The grove was enclosed with large stones and was filled with bushes growing all kinds of berries, a pool of clean,

glowing water, and all other kinds of pleasantries. I was welcomed by an old frost giant named Ulvir.

Ulvir explained that he is an old druid of the land Circle. We spoke for a while about what could be done about Norbury, but Ulvir could do nothing. The blight is too strong, and Ulvir has become weak. Eventually, Ulvir stopped speaking and just stared at me for a while. The next words Ulvir spoke completely changed the trajectory of my life. He offered to indoctrinate me into the Circle of land and give me the power to change the fate of Norbury.

If I can save Norbury, I think I can make up for what I have done. I think I can finally be free of my past.

I am currently in a bar in Skive, getting ready to board a ship to Lyndon. I am supposed to be helping a merchant named Gerard get through the journey safely, but I am more concerned with myself being on a ship.

I apologize for not having the courage to tell you my story in person, but it is easier for me to write it rather than speak it.

I look forward to seeing you.

Sincerely,

Thomas Elnath.

